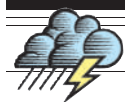


The Washington Post

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Democracy Dies in Darkness

WEDNESDAY, AUGUST 13, 2025 • \$4

Staff shift from shock to fury after CDC attack

Many fault RFK Jr. and Trump for ‘vilification’ of the agency, covid vaccine

BY LAUREN WEBER
AND LENA H. SUN

KENNESAW, GA. — A gaunt Patrick White approached his neighbor on her porch last year to deliver a warning, she recalled. Coronavirus vaccines harmed him and others. Authorities were covering this up.

On Friday afternoon, he fired hundreds of bullets at six buildings on the Atlanta headquarters of the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, officials allege, forcing hundreds of workers into lockdown as gunfire bombarded windows around them. White died of a self-inflicted gunshot wound, and his gunfire killed a responding police officer — a father of two children with a third on the way, law enforcement officials said during a Tuesday news conference.

Investigators said they found documentation at White’s residence expressing his discontent with coronavirus vaccination. “The overall content of one of the documents was more of wanting to make the public aware of his distrust of the vaccines,” said Chris Hosey, director of the Georgia Bureau of Investigation.

For many in public health, the shooting seemed to vindicate their long-running fears that the backlash to their work during the coronavirus pandemic could turn deadly. Some left the field after a vitriolic response to mandates for masking and vaccination. Armed protesters gathered outside the homes of health officials. Some health officials faced death threats, including Anthony S. Fauci, one of the leaders of the federal coronavirus response.

Days after the shooting, the initial shock has morphed into anger for many CDC employees, according to interviews with more than a dozen of them, most of whom spoke on the condition of anonymity out of fear of retaliation.

They fault President Donald Trump for not publicly condemning the shooting as of Tuesday, even as he invoked the assault of a former U.S. DOGE Service staffer to deploy troops in D.C. and take over its police department. They said they are fed up with how they and their work are being derided and impugned by conservatives and anti-vaccine

SEE CDC ON A8

Plan calls for Guard ‘reaction force’



CRAIG HUDSON/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Members of the National Guard in D.C. on Tuesday, after President Donald Trump authorized the mobilization of 800 troops in the city.

Police takeover playbook, steeped in years of complaints, was at the ready

BY MATT VISER,
EMILY DAVIES
AND PERRY STEIN

Even before he took office, President Donald Trump had an informal playbook for how he would use the powers of the presidency to take control of the District of Columbia, with options prepared for him such as deploying more federal law enforcement officers or taking over the entire municipal government.

The only questions, according to two people briefed on White House deliberations, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to

detail private conversations, were which option he would choose and when he would opt to implement it.

Those questions were answered Monday morning, when Trump federalized the D.C. police department and authorized some 800 National Guard troops to patrol city streets alongside its officers. Speaking to a packed White House briefing room, he gave them a far-reaching mandate to clear homeless encampments, make arrests and “to do whatever the hell they want” in curbing crime — an exertion of

SEE POLICE ON A7

President’s vision of a dystopia is shared by his MAGA movement

This article is by Cleve R. Wootson Jr., Karen Tumulty, Drew Harwell, Clara Ence Morse and Jonathan Edwards

Moments after signing an executive order giving himself control of D.C.’s police force, President Donald Trump painted a dystopian picture of the city he wants to “take back” from crime.

Mobs of teenagers roam the streets, the president told the country from the White House briefing room on Monday. A “band of roving thugs” beat a member of his own administration. Law-abiding residents and

visitors alike agonize over trips to national monuments, the grocery store and even the mailbox, worried about becoming victims of rampant, random crime.

“Our capital city has been overtaken by violent gangs and blood-thirsty criminals, roving mobs of wild youth, drugged-out maniacs and homeless people,” Trump said after holding up a chart comparing D.C.’s homicide rate to killings in South American countries plagued by drug-related violence. “Entire neighborhoods are now under emergency curfews.”

Monday’s 80-minute news

SEE MAGA ON A5

Directive orders aggressive review of exhibits in 8 Smithsonian museums

BY JANAY KINGSBERRY

The White House will launch a sweeping review of Smithsonian exhibitions, collections and operations ahead of America’s 250th birthday celebrations next year — the first time the Trump administration has detailed steps to scrutinize the institution, which offi-

cials say should reflect the president’s call to restore “truth and sanity” to American history.

The vetting process would include reviewing public-facing and online content, curatorial processes and guidelines, exhibition planning and collection use, according to a letter sent to Smithsonian Secretary Lonnie G.

Bunch III on Tuesday and signed by White House senior associate Lindsey Halligan, Domestic Policy Council Director Vince Hale and White House Office of Management and Budget chief Russell Vought.

A White House official confirmed the plan, which was posted on the White House website

Tuesday and first reported by the Wall Street Journal.

The Smithsonian did not immediately respond to requests for comment.

The institution already planned its own content review, ordered by the Smithsonian’s Board of Regents in June amid pressure from President Donald

Trump. The regents instructed Bunch “to ensure unbiased content” across the institution and report back on “any needed personnel changes.”

The board at that time affirmed Bunch’s authority amid a high-stakes standoff between the White House and Kim Sajet,

SEE SMITHSONIAN ON A14

‘Mining mafia’ supplies gold for Beijing

Chinese syndicates run illegal, destructive operations on three continents

BY REBECCA TAN

LANTUNG VILLAGE, INDONESIA — Hilltop after hilltop in this remote part of Indonesia is being scalped of vegetation. On the horizon, excavators lumber forward, gouging out rocks veined yellow. Nearby, milky chemicals collect in Olympic pool-sized trenches.

This is the work of Chinese mining syndicates flush with capital and connections, Indonesian investigators say. And virtually none of it is legal.

These syndicates bring their own geologic maps, excavators and leaching tanks. They operate without permits, unchecked by local police — the equivalent of what residents call a “mining mafia,” in control of the most lucrative resource in these hills: gold.

“We don’t know where they take it,” said a Lantung gold trader, Heru Hairuddin. “We only know it doesn’t stay here.”

As part of a strategic effort to reduce reliance on the U.S. dollar, insulate itself from potential U.S. sanctions and build its own capacity to influence the international monetary system, China is procuring gold at a voracious pace. This drive has fueled and facilitated a surge in illicit gold mining across the Global South, inflicting a trail of environmental destruction from Indonesia to Ghana to French Guiana, a Washington Post investigation found.

The Post examination of China’s role in the booming trade in illicit gold is based on a review of satellite imagery, trade data, public records, and dozens of interviews with gold researchers, law

enforcement and government officials across three continents. In Indonesia, where the proliferation of illicit mining has been among the most widespread and least studied, The Post obtained internal government documents and visited a half-dozen secluded gold-mining communities being transformed by Chinese-led operations.

Chinese workers at these locations declined to speak to The Post, but Chinese mining operators in Indonesia said in interviews that investment in the country’s gold sector is spiking. In videos aimed at investors on Chinese social media, Chinese miners advertise “free and easy” access to Indonesia’s vast gold deposits.

In May, the United Nations

SEE CHINA ON A10



MUHAMMAD FADLI/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

A Chinese-operated gold mine is seen near Lantung village on the Indonesian island of Sumbawa.

IN THE NEWS

Summit with Putin Ukraine’s Volodymyr Zelensky criticized Donald Trump’s planned meeting with Russia’s leader as the U.S. president himself tempered expectations. **A12**

Human rights reports The annual State Department assessment arrived a half-year late with significant cuts and little fanfare. **A18**

THE NATION An audit found severe staffing shortages at every Veterans Affairs medical center. **A2**
Changes appear to be in store for the Kennedy Center’s marquee awards ceremony. **A3**

THE WORLD Key allies of Israel said it must give relief agencies full access to Gaza to halt starvation. **A9**
A U.S. grand jury indicted a Haitian gang leader on sanctions-related charges. **A12**

THE ECONOMY New data suggested tariffs are driving up the costs of everyday goods, even as lower energy prices helped moderate overall increases. **A13**
The nominee to lead the Bureau of Labor Statistics endorsed suspending monthly jobs reports. **A13**

STYLE Lee Tilghman’s new memoir delves into the dark side of the influencer industry that nearly ruined her life. **B1**

SPORTS Evgeny Kuznetsov, the former Capitals star, drops in to skate with the locals in a Ballston beer league. **B7**

THE REGION A GOP congressman has taken aim at a protest near the White House that has lasted for 44 years. **B13**

FOOD It’s the era of peak protein. Here’s what a day full of pumped-up popcorn, pasta and water tastes like. **E1**

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